

Exegesis of Luke 1:39-56

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³⁹ In those days Mary set out and went with haste to a Judean town in the hill country,
⁴⁰ where she entered the house of Zechariah and greeted Elizabeth. ⁴¹ When Elizabeth
 heard Mary's greeting, the child leaped in her womb. And Elizabeth was filled with the
 Holy Spirit ⁴² and exclaimed with a loud cry, "Blessed are you among women, and
 blessed is the fruit of your womb. ⁴³ And why has this happened to me, that the mother of
 my Lord comes to me? ⁴⁴ For as soon as I heard the sound of your greeting, the child in
 my womb leaped for joy. ⁴⁵ And blessed is she who believed that there would be a
 fulfillment of what was spoken to her by the Lord."

⁴⁶ And Mary said,

"My soul magnifies the Lord,
⁴⁷ and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior,
⁴⁸ for he has looked with favor on the lowliness of his servant.
 Surely, from now on all generations will call me blessed;
⁴⁹ for the Mighty One has done great things for me,
 and holy is his name.
⁵⁰ His mercy is for those who fear him
 from generation to generation.
⁵¹ He has shown strength with his arm;
 he has scattered the proud in the thoughts of their hearts.
⁵² He has brought down the powerful from their thrones,
 and lifted up the lowly;
⁵³ he has filled the hungry with good things,
 and sent the rich away empty.
⁵⁴ He has helped his servant Israel,
 in remembrance of his mercy,
⁵⁵ according to the promise he made to our ancestors,
 to Abraham and to his descendants forever."

⁵⁶ And Mary remained with her about three months and then returned to her home.
 (Lk. 1:39-56)

At the beginning of his gospel account, Luke introduces the audience to his protagonist, Jesus Christ. His goal is to identify the nature and mission of Jesus and to establish the primary themes of his gospel before Jesus assumes center stage. He understands that the story of Jesus is not the beginning, but is rather the promised end, for which countless Israelites had longed and expected. Luke builds upon the Israelites' expectations by drawing parallels to the Old Testament scriptures.

The visitation of Mary to her relative Elizabeth, as written by Luke, artfully merges the two women's stories together to form a sense of amplitude in the opening narrative of the gospel (Johnson 43). This pivotal scene is a mosaic of various literary and theological elements that embody the remainder of Luke's gospel. The visitation sequence offers initial characterizations of God the Father, Jesus, and the Holy Spirit that will lay the foundation for the audience's understanding of God's action throughout the subsequent narrative. Through the faithful responses to God's action by Mary, Elizabeth, and John, the visitation scene establishes Jesus's

conception as the critical turning point of salvation history. Jesus's conception is itself the fulfillment of past promises and marks the inauguration of Jesus's eternal saving reign.

In Greco-Roman literature, infancy narratives were a literary device used to reveal the backstory or hidden motivations and abilities of a character (Kuhn 79). Legends, hyperbole, and factual accounts were often blended together into a single story of the character in their childhood. Seeing the individual as a child provides the audience with a deeper understanding and emotional connection to the character. Luke similarly uses Jesus's infancy narrative as prelude to His eventual ministry (*TCSB* 1435). The audience, having previewed the significance and potential that Jesus possessed as a child, is left with an expectant desire to learn more about the holy child after He "increased in wisdom and in years, and in divine and human favor," (Lk. 2:52). This anticipation is heightened by Luke's repeated use of the proclamation and fulfillment motif, wherein he employs dialogue or exposition to predict a future event that will see its fulfillment later in the narrative (Green 49).

Luke sets the scene for his gospel in "the days of King Herod in Judea," (Lk. 1:5). Although this certainly gives a historical and even a social¹ introduction to this narrative, Luke nudges his audience to understand that his gospel is hardly the beginning of the story. Rather, Luke repeatedly recalls Israelite traditions, inviting his audience to see his gospel as a continuation of the story of Israel that unfolded throughout the Old Testament. Episodes such as the annunciations to Zechariah (Lk. 1:5-25) and Mary (Lk. 1:26-38) mirror the annunciations of the births of Ishmael (Gen. 16:7-13), Isaac (Gen. 17:1-22), and Samson (Jdg. 13:2-21) (Tannehill 15). I & II Samuel are alluded to throughout the infancy narrative: Elizabeth, barren in her old age (Lk. 1:7), resembles the barren Hannah (I Sam. 1:5); Hannah's song of joy for the miraculous conception of her son (I Sam 2:1-10) is likewise echoed by Mary (Lk. 1:46-55) and Zechariah (Lk. 1:67-79); Samuel's dedication (I Sam. 2:18-21, 26) and childhood (I Sam. 3) in the temple reflect Jesus's presentation (Lk. 2:22-38) and recovery (Lk. 2:41-52) from the temple (Tannehill 18). Even beyond his many parallels to the Old Testament, Luke reinforces the Israelite foundation of his narrative by setting it into a deeply Semitic atmosphere. The opening scene of the gospel follows Zechariah, a priest belonging to the order of Abijah, making an offering of incense in the temple (Lk. 1:5-10). Scenes in the temple form an *inclusio* around the entire infancy narrative, alerting the audience to the prominence of the temple throughout the remainder of Luke-Acts (Green 61). The characters too are described according to their Israelite lineage and devotedness to Torah.² Jesus Himself is first introduced by the angel with respect to His Davidic ancestry and predicts His coming reign over the house of Jacob (Lk. 1:32-33). The image couldn't be clearer to an Israelite community under Roman and Herodian occupation: Jesus is the fulfillment of their hopes for a messiah (Tannehill 19).

Because of their proximity to each other in the text, even stronger than Luke's many allusions to Israelite tradition is the step-parallelism between the stories of John and Jesus. Each episode of John's infancy is followed by a corresponding episode in Jesus's infancy. The opening narrative starts with an introduction to John's parents (1:5-7), Gabriel's announcement

¹ Just by introducing them in the same sentence, Luke draws attention to the dichotomy between King Herod (whom Luke's audience would associate with certain negative images) and the "righteous" and "blameless" Zechariah and Elizabeth (1:6).

² Zechariah and Elizabeth "were righteous before God, living blamelessly according to all the commandments and regulations of the Lord," (1:6); Mary and Joseph, obedient to Torah, "offered a sacrifice according to what is stated in the law of the Lord," (2:24); Simeon "was righteous and devout, looking forward to the consolation of Israel," (2:25); Anna "never left the temple" and preached "to all who were looking for the redemption of Jerusalem," (2:37-38).

of John's miraculous birth (1:8-23), and Elizabeth's joyful response to her pregnancy (1:24-25). This sequence of events is followed by an introduction to Jesus's parents (1:26-27), Gabriel's announcement of Jesus's miraculous birth (1:28-38), and the Mary's joyful response to her pregnancy (1:46-55). In a similar fashion, John's birth (1:57-58), circumcision (1:59-66), and the prophetic response to his birth (1:67-79) directly precede Jesus's birth (2:1-20), circumcision (2:21), and the prophetic response to His birth (2:27-35) (Green 50). Luke uses these patterns, however, to accentuate the superiority of Jesus over John. Although John will turn the hearts of Israel to prepare for the coming of the Lord (1:16-17), it will be Jesus who eventually reigns over the house of Israel (1:33). While John is described as "great in the sight of the Lord" (1:15), Jesus is "great" without qualification (1:32). John, Zechariah says, will be "the prophet of the Most High" (1:76), whereas Gabriel calls Jesus "the Son of the most High" (1:32) (Green 51). Elizabeth and Mary are also contrasted: Elizabeth notes that the Lord "looked favorably" on her (1:25), qualified by a past action, while Mary is pronounced as "favored one" by Gabriel (1:28), qualified by a state of being. The step-parallelism between John and Jesus also reveals John's function relative to Jesus. By preceding each episode of Jesus's infancy, Luke narratively portrays John as going before the Lord and preparing His ways (1:17, 76), "even before his birth," (1:15) (*TLSB* 1705).

The imbalance between John and Jesus intensifies when the characters from the two annunciation scenes come together. The convergence of these storylines confirms any previous suspicions of parallelism during the annunciation scenes by disclosing the relationship between Elizabeth and Mary and solidifies Jesus and Mary's exalted status over John and Elizabeth (Tannehill 17). Luke also uses this scene to advance the plotline of the infancy narrative: Mary's journey to the country hills of Judea shifts the audience's attention back to Elizabeth, allowing her to stay on stage during the following scene (Green 93). This is Luke's first use of the travel motif in Luke-Acts. Luke alerts the audience to the significance of Mary's journey with his threefold use of the word "into" to describe her movement (Nolland 65).³ It is also noteworthy that Mary would travel at all after the recent announcement of her pregnancy. It would be greatly unusual for a pregnant, young woman like herself to travel seventy miles from her hometown, especially since Luke neither indicates whether she is being accompanied by anybody else, nor what her intentions are for visiting Elizabeth (Green 94-95). This journey, like the ones to follow in Luke, further unifies the infancy narrative by blending multiple episodes of the story into one. However, Mary's visit to Elizabeth advances the plot beyond mere physical progression.

The passage shows us as well how Luke uses dialogue to advance the story, or, more properly, to advance the reader's understanding of the story. Notice how Elizabeth knows (and reveals to the reader as she speaks to Mary) dimensions of Mary's conditions and Jesus' status previously undisclosed. The resumptive character of such dialogue also enables Luke to emphasize how previously stated prophecies have been fulfilled, and future ones will be (1:41, 45). (Johnson 43)

The lack of disclosed intention and details preceding Mary's journey gives the transition to the visitation scene an almost impulsive atmosphere (1:39). This spontaneity is accentuated by the detail of the "haste" with which Mary went to greet Elizabeth (Green 95). It is important

³ Mary first went "into" ("εἰς") the hill country (1:39), then went "into" ("εἰς") a Judean town (1:39), and finally "into" ("εἰς") the house of Zechariah (1:40).

to recognize that Mary's visit was not motivated by a desire to validate Gabriel's claim of Elizabeth's pregnancy; Luke was already clear about Mary's unqualified faith in his declaration (Craddock 29).

Since Elizabeth was both the wife of a priest and older than Mary (Elizabeth was "getting on in years" (1:7) whereas Mary was a betrothed virgin (1:27) and was therefore likely young), Mary would have typically been regarded as subordinate to Elizabeth's seniority in terms of status and age. Thus, it was proper that Mary should be the first to extend a greeting to her relative. Just as he did when describing her journey into the house of Zechariah, Luke again highlights the action of Mary in her greeting of Elizabeth (1:40). Despite the threefold use of the word "greeting,"⁴ Luke does not divulge the contents of her greeting (Green 94). This lack of detail is in accordance with the hastiness that has encompassed this event up until this point. And, in like manner, the lack of detail also advances the narrative to see the major action of the scene: John's prenatal leaping and Elizabeth's prophetic response. Luke uses the concision of this interaction to tie Gabriel's prophecy (namely, Jesus's conception) as close as possible to the revelation of its fulfillment.

Of Elizabeth, Gabriel prophesied that she will bear a son (1:13) and "have great joy and gladness" (1:14). Of her son, Gabriel prophesied that he "will be filled with the Holy Spirit" (1:15) and will prepare people for the coming of the Lord (1:17). John's leaping at the preborn Jesus's presence (1:41) is a manifestation of the fulfillment of all of the above prophecies. From the womb of aged Elizabeth, John miraculously leaps (with "joy," as later indicated by Elizabeth [1:44]) to announce the eschatological arrival of God. The leaping of John and exclamatory joy of Elizabeth in this moment certainly reflect the great joy and gladness expected by the angel. Likewise, the Holy Spirit's action within the miracle of infant's prenatal leap and within the mother's exclamation show that they, as foretold by the angel, are filled with the Holy Spirit. Finally, John's leap both prepares Elizabeth to acknowledge the presence of the Lord following statement (1:43) and, as a result, implicitly designates Jesus with the title of "Lord," since it is the Lord for whom John is destined to prepare (Green 95).

Jewish tradition is familiar with the idea that unborn children may take part in events of the world and anticipate prenatally their later positions in life... . While Elizabeth responds to the greeting, the unborn John responds directly to the presence of the unborn Jesus. (Nolland 66)

Keeping his gospel continually connected to prior Israelite traditions, Luke possibly uses this event to once again recast Old Testament literature. Esau and Jacob's struggle with one another within the previously barren womb of Rebekah (Gen. 25:22) is an antitype of John and Jesus's relationship. Unlike Esau and Jacob, John and Jesus do not struggle; rather, John's movement within the womb is prompted by gladness in the presence of Jesus. However, like Esau and Jacob, "the one shall be stronger than the other, the elder shall serve the younger," (Gen. 25:23). John, like Esau, would be destined to serve the younger, stronger child, though, unlike Esau, he would happily oblige to his vocation. Rebekah too, similar to Hannah, can be seen as clearly prefiguring Elizabeth since her womb was opened in spite of her barrenness (Gen. 25:21) (Craddock 29). The description of John's leaping as a response to Mary's greeting forms

⁴ Mary went to the house of Zechariah and "greeted" ("ἡσπασατο") Elizabeth (1:40), then John leaped at the sound of her "greeting" ("ἁσπασμου") (1:41), and finally Elizabeth acknowledges John's leap at the sound of her "greeting" ("ἁσπασμου") (1:44).

an *inclusio* around Elizabeth's Spirit-filled response, drawing attention to the significance of her exclamation in light of John's prophetic action.

Elizabeth's opening statement proclaims the blessedness of both Mary and her developing child, following the classic Semitic form of a double blessing, wherein the first line identifies the human recipient of the blessing and the second line identifies the divine source of the blessing. Elizabeth expresses Mary's blessedness in a way that may recall the blessedness of Jael (Jdg. 5:24) and Judith (Jdt. 13:18) in the Old Testament. This comparison is appropriate because it frames the role of Mary in the tradition of other heroines through whom God brought the deliverance of Israel (Nolland 67).⁵

Interestingly, Elizabeth's acknowledgement of Mary's high status contradicts the societal understanding of honor (Green 96). As stated earlier, Mary would have typically been regarded as subordinate to Elizabeth's seniority in terms of status and age; however, Elizabeth's proclamation of Mary as blessed "among women" (1:42) subordinates herself to Mary. Such a statement challenges the cultural norm because Elizabeth ascribes undue honor to the lowly virgin. Elizabeth again confirms her subjugation to Mary when, overwhelmed with proper reverence in the presence of God, she questions her worthiness to receive Mary into her hospitality (1:43) (Nolland 67). However, the most dramatic piece of Elizabeth's response is her recognition of Jesus as "Lord." Elizabeth is the first of many to identify Jesus as "Lord" in Luke-Acts (Kuhn 130). Not only does Elizabeth announce to the audience that Jesus has been conceived and is present in the womb of Mary (a piece of information that Luke had left hidden until now), she also professes her servanthood to Him. Even from His mother's womb, Jesus is already identified as reigning over Israel in a manner consistent with Gabriel's prophecy.⁶ Since "Lord" almost exclusively refers to God in the Old Testament, Elizabeth's use of the term "Lord" also leaves open a possible association with Jesus as Himself being, or at least as being closely related to, God (Johnson 41). This prophetic revelation by Elizabeth, in addition to her ability to decipher this as the cause of John's prenatal movements (1:44), is the result of the Holy Spirit's inspiration within her outburst mentioned earlier in the text (Spence 9).

Having now identified Mary's previously undisclosed pregnancy, it is clear that the focal point of Mary's blessedness, according to Elizabeth, is her motherhood of Jesus (Green 96). Elizabeth again affirms Mary's blessedness⁷ with respect to her motherhood when she commends Mary's belief "that there would be a fulfillment of what was spoken to her by the Lord," (1:45). Elizabeth's praise for Mary's faith in the fulfillment of Gabriel's word appears to be a Lukan reformulation of Gabriel's condemnation of Zechariah because he "did not believe [Gabriel's] words, which will be fulfilled in their time," (1:20). Thus, Mary, for her faith, is the antithesis of the doubtful Zechariah (Nolland 68). This contrast supports Luke's use of step-parallelism to show Jesus and Mary's superiority over John and his parents. It also again reinforces Elizabeth's conviction that Gabriel's prophecy was fulfilled, which is crucial because the fulfillment of this

⁵ Mary's connection to Jael and Judith, two women who were noted to have crushed the heads of their enemies (Jdg. 4:21, 5:26; Jdt. 13:8, 18b), may imply a fulfillment of the prophecy given to the serpent that "the woman" and her "offspring" will strike his head (Gen. 3:15).

⁶ In this way, Jesus reflects His ancestor David, the "lord" (1 Kings 1:31) who also reigned over the house of Israel.

⁷ Unlike her previous two uses of the term, Elizabeth's final use of the term "blessed" uses the Greek "*μακαρια*" which specifies the perfect nature of Mary's blessedness. The word "*μακαρια*" is later used by Jesus in the Beatitudes to refer to the righteousness of the poor, hungry, weeping, and persecuted (6:20-22).

word (that is, Mary's motherhood) is the foundation of Elizabeth's certainty of Mary's blessedness.⁸

Fulfillment continues to be a focus of Luke's infancy narrative. In the visitation scene, the fulfillment of Gabriel's prophecy is revealed. However, the significance of this revelation goes well beyond the humble characters of Elizabeth and Mary. Luke always keeps the bigger picture in view, allowing the audience to grasp the insurmountable implications of the conception of Jesus. Even as an infant in Mary's womb, Jesus is revealed by His forerunner to be the messiah, destined to rule over the house of Israel from His Davidic throne. He is Himself the fulfillment of the hopes of all of Israel and brings with Him the present opportunity of deliverance. Jesus's conception is, at the time of Mary's visitation, the high point of salvation history. Mary is aware of this and therefore, overwhelmed with joy, she gives her response.

The Magnificat is like an aria in opera; the action almost stops so that the situation may be savored more deeply. At the same time, this savored meaning contributes to the flow of the narrative, for Mary's song both develops a mood which has already been established and opens perspectives that will be more fully developed in the following canticles. (Tannehill 31)

The last two scenes placed Mary in center stage, allowing the audience to understand some preliminary aspects of Mary's character, background, and role in Luke's gospel. These two scenes contributed to the buildup of joy that is released in Mary's song.⁹ Luke uses Mary's song as a preface to and a celebration of Jesus's inaugurated reign in His kingdom, a heavily Lukan theme that defines the remainder of Luke-Acts (Kuhn 131). Mary's song is also presented as the first of several character speeches delivered throughout Luke-Acts. Luke uses character speeches to guide the audience's understanding of recent events (Johnson 43) in order to provide the audience a correct framework for interpreting the following episodes (Kuhn 128). Therefore, Lukan character speeches must be carefully crafted so that the character's response to the recent events is an apt reflection of the event in light of the primary themes of Luke's gospel. In this sense, Mary's song should be seen as Mary's interpretation of Jesus's conception in a way that underlines its effect on certain Lukan themes.¹⁰

Mary's song begins as a deeply personal prayer. She expresses her praise in her feelings of joy, expressing also the role of her soul and spirit in lifting her prayer to God. Mary's "soul," she says, magnifies the Lord (1:46), which is in contrast to her "spirit" which rejoices in God, her savior (1:47). This initial inward description of her praise is a distinguishing mark of Israelite

⁸ This twofold blessedness, in both motherhood and the acceptance God's word, is repeated during Jesus's ministry when a woman cries, "Blessed is the womb that bore you and the breasts that nursed you!" (11:27) and Jesus replies, "Blessed rather are those who hear the word of God and obey it!" (11:28). Mary, as expressed here by Elizabeth's cry, is blessed in both ways (Johnson 41).

⁹ Some old manuscripts suggest that Elizabeth, not Mary, delivered the following canticle. This idea is primarily based upon the fact that, if no antecedent had originally been given, Elizabeth would be the natural subject of the verb "said" ("εἶπεν") (1:46), considering she had been the speaker in the preceding verses (Tinsley 32). However, Elizabeth being the speaker would both diminish the eschatological significance of the song and lead to an awkward self-appraisal of blessedness (1:48) considering Elizabeth's recognition of Mary's blessedness mere sentences ago (1:42, 45) (Nolland 68).

¹⁰ Whether or not Mary literally delivered her song in response to Elizabeth is impossible to know for sure. She, like Elizabeth, may have received the inspiration of the Holy Spirit necessary to make up the whole song on the spot; however, the text is silent about this. Therefore, it is possible that Luke wrote the speech, intricately modeling it as an idealized version of any response that Mary would have given to Elizabeth's blessing.

poetry, especially since it employs the unique distinction between her soul and spirit, (Johnson 41). Simultaneous with her distinction of “soul” and “spirit” is Mary’s alternation between the terms “Lord” and “God” in reference to the divine object of her praise. This too is a common practice within Old Testament poetic literature, such as in the psalms, and does not have theological meaning beyond highlighting multiple different attributes of God (Nolland 68). The term “magnifies” is used in other places of Luke-Acts to refer to a particular kind of exaltation that enlarges the object of praise.¹¹ Likewise, the rejoicing of Mary’s spirit recalls the same kind of joy that was experienced earlier by the infant John in response to Mary’s greeting. This combination of magnification and joy is experienced again by the attendants of John’s nativity (1:58). These connections bear further witness to the parallelism between Mary and Elizabeth in the infancy narrative.

With her description of God as her “savior,” Mary is the first to introduce the audience to the theme of salvation which permeates Luke-Acts (Johnson 42).¹² This honorific that she applies to God is used in the Old Testament to refer to both physical and spiritual salvation (*TLSB* 1707). Because Mary’s application of the term assumes God’s present role in her salvation, both cases provide their own sets of difficulties. Not faced with any personal physical calamity, it is unclear what God is presently saving Mary from. In this case, it is more likely that Mary is referring to salvation in a greater sense – a salvation which has already been inaugurated with the conception of Jesus – that is, the salvation fulfilled by the coming of the messiah. Thus, God’s physical salvation of Mary is actually the salvation which He offers to all of Israel as the fulfillment of their hopes and expectations of a messiah (Nolland 69). However, additional tension also arises if the salvation that Mary refers to is spiritual. Although atonement theology is not a prominent theme in Luke’s narrative, the idea that Jesus’s life was given up for His disciples is still present in Luke-Acts (22:20) (Kuhn 220). Since Jesus had not yet given up His life by the time that Mary delivered her canticle, Mary’s present spiritual salvation could not have been a result of His atonement. However, in conjunction with Gabriel’s address of Mary as “favored one” (1:28), it is possible that Mary’s personal spiritual salvation had already begun to bear fruit prior to Jesus’s conception.¹³

Old Testament poetry literature, which Mary’s song imitates, often begins with a statement indicating the direction of praise followed by an explanation of the reasons for praise. Mary praises the Lord God, her savior, for His regard for the “lowliness of His servant” (1:48). Mary, who earlier identified herself as the “servant” of the Lord (1:38), is undoubtedly referring to God’s regard for her lowliness. This establishes the focus of her thanksgiving as entirely upward in direction. Not directing any attention to herself, Mary describes her lowliness as an objective condition of her being. By describing herself as lowly instead of humble (or any other subjective attitude), she avoids any self-righteous assertion, demonstrating her humility without needing to draw any attention to it (Kretzmann 266). Additionally, by confessing her low stature, she enumerates herself among the ranks of the poor and powerless who receive God’s favor later in her song (Johnson 42). Mary does not intimate a knowledge of why God has

¹¹ Such as when “the name of the Lord Jesus” received praise/magnification (“εμεγαλυνετο”) after the all the residents of Ephesus were awestruck in the aftermath of an exorcism attempted in His name (Ac. 19:15-17).

¹² Interestingly, the baby currently in her womb receives the designation of “savior” later in the infancy narrative (2:11). This also prepares the audience for the soteriological emphasis of Zechariah and Simeon’s canticles.

¹³ This is the foundation of the Roman Catholic belief in Mary’s immaculate conception. Mary’s favored state could be a result of God, as her savior, preserving her from the stain of original sin even before the atonement of Jesus.

looked upon her with favor; by acknowledging His favor, she merely rejoices in gratitude for the mercy that she has received (Bruce 1188).

Mary does, however, express an understanding, if only partial, of the magnitude of mercy that she has received. She points to an unspecified turning point that recently occurred (“from now on”), after which she expects that generations to come will recognize her blessedness for God’s action to her. This is a reaction to Elizabeth’s prior recognition of Mary as doubly blessed, implicitly designating Elizabeth as the first of many generations that will bless Mary for her motherhood (Tannehill 32). The turning point that Mary suggests is of course Jesus’s conception. For Mary, that is the fulcrum, not just for her life, but for the history of Israel’s salvation (Nolland 70). Mary affirms this expanded view of the significance of Jesus’s conception when she praises God for the “great things” that He has done for her (1:49). Jesus’s conception was a singular event, yet the “great things” for which Mary rejoices are plural. “In Mary’s case *μεγάλα*, ‘great things,’ is no true plural... but a stereotypical reflection of OT language of God’s saving intervention (especially of the exodus). In the Greek text *μεγάλα* nicely picks up the *μεγαλύνει*, ‘magnifies,’ of v 46b,” (Nolland 70). The statement paired with this continues this Old Testament allusion by expressing the holiness of God’s name. Israelites regarded God’s name, the name which He gave to Moses (Exo. 3:14), as uniquely set apart and, therefore, holy. The great things done to her by the mighty one are a subtle antithesis to Mary’s confession of her lowly servitude. The servant submissively has an action done to her for her lowliness, whereas God, in His mightiness, is the holy performer of these great actions to her.

Mary transitions the recipient of God’s mercy in her song from the first to third person, expanding the object of this mercy now to all those “who fear Him,” (1:50). This general terminology does not limit God’s mercy to Mary, nor even to Israel, but rather to all people who fear Him. She amplifies this statement by proclaiming that God’s mercy reaches “from generation to generation.” The twofold use of “generation” functions both to identify the two peoples that may inherit His mercy and to verbally represent the magnitude of that combined group. The two peoples, Jews and Gentiles, may both rightly revere God (Bede). This notion that anyone, indiscriminate of ethnicity or status (including lowly Mary), may receive His mercy becomes a prominent feature of Jesus’s ministry. Therefore, Luke uses this segment of Mary’s song to lay the groundwork of that aspect of Jesus’s ministry for his audience.

The transition to the third person Israelite recipient of God’s mercy is completed when Mary expresses the strength shown by God’s arm by scattering the proud (1:51). This is another Old Testament reference to God, whose “outstretched arm” redeemed the people of Israel from their exodus (Exo. 6:6) and who “scattered” their enemies (Num. 10:35). Mary is announcing the inauguration of a new exodus, one that is directly connected to the action that God, her savior, has done for her. In a sense, the saving action that God has done for Mary is representative of His saving action for Israel that began with the conception of Jesus (Tannehill 29). These similarities are woven together through parallel images of Mary and Israel in both halves of the canticle (Green 101).¹⁴ This pattern shows that the lowly virgin, by the exalting favor God showed her through the conception of Jesus, is an heir of God’s promised salvation. That salvation which He promised to Israel will likewise be manifest through Jesus’s coming reign.

Mary’s song is littered with internal parallelisms, but none more explicit than the chiasm that makes up the literary climax of the canticle. Mary dramatically illustrates the societal revolution that God will institute in His kingdom: those who previously had great status or power

¹⁴ Figure I provided on page 14 shows the explicit parallels between God’s favor for Mary and those for Israel.

will be removed from their thrones, but those who were objectively lowly¹⁵ will be lifted up (1:52); the needy who were once hungry and destitute will be satiated with more food than they need, but the rich who had excessive food will end up hungry like the needy were earlier (1:53). Even the use of a chiasmic structure contributes to the image of reversal, since the paralleled couplets are flipped, here following an A-B-B-A structure (Tannehill 28). The chiasm is surrounded by yet another couplet whose opening is antithetical to its closing. In the opening, the proud are the object of God's judgmental action, whereas the closing focuses on the servile Israel is the object of God's merciful action (Nolland 73). These stark contrasts declare the universal repercussions of the fulfillment of God's promises. Mary is speaking about something beyond simply spiritual reality. With vivid words, she is undoubtedly painting a picture of the physical dimension of God's salvation.¹⁶ Mary is announcing the advent of great political, economic, social, and religious reversal all at the same time (Kuhn 134). This is even more apparent (and controversial) when considering the implications of such a societal revolution. Mary was, in a way, prophesying the dismantling of the present Roman and Herodian civil structure, the reversal of the honor system, and the destruction of the temple hierarchy.

The artistry and meaning of Mary's song is enhanced when considering the grammar of the original Greek. Powerful action verbs begin each major line of text.¹⁷ This pattern continues until the end of both halves of the song, after which the primary action of each strophe declines with the disappearance of any dominant action verbs (Tannehill 26-27).¹⁸ In almost every case, the subject of these verbs is God. As such, Mary is not inciting human action, but is rather drawing attention to God's agency (Green 100). She is proclaiming the role of God as the divine agent of mercy, not only in the ways that are specifically listed in the canticle, but also in the recent events of the infancy narrative. Of great importance, also, is the verb tense. All of the vivid, active verbs at the beginning of each line are written in the Greek aorist tense. Since the aorist tense describes past events without defining a conclusion, it is possible to assume that the actions of God stated in Mary's song have not yet ended (Craddock 30). This interpretive possibility becomes likely when considering the context of these verbs. The past event to which Mary is referring as the beginning of these actions is Jesus's conception. Jesus hasn't even been born yet, but still His conception has initiated all of the actions listed in her song. Surely He whose kingdom will have no end will not allow the acts of mercy that are already in motion to cease. By using the aorist tense, Mary is truly conveying the eschatological significance of Jesus's conception as both the present and eternal cause of mercy.

The canticle concludes with Israel's history once again in view. Mary recalls all of the promises that God made to His people in the past (1:54) with a distinct focus on His covenant with Abraham¹⁹ (1:55). Mary is clearly trying to stress the connection between Israelite tradition

¹⁵ It is especially appropriate that Mary is the speaker since she truly embodies the lowly being lifted up. She, despite her lowliness, was blessed with the great things of God's favor.

¹⁶ The picture that Mary paints bears close resemblance to Jesus's sermon on the plain later in Luke. Mary's statements that the lowly will be raised, the powerful brought down, the hungry filled, and the full left empty are almost exactly repeated in the beatitudes and woes (6:20-26).

¹⁷ Figure II provided on page 14 helpfully rewrites the canticle showing how the Greek text highlights action verbs throughout the piece.

¹⁸ This pattern confirms the intentionality behind the previously mentioned division of the song into two halves during the transition from the first to the third person.

¹⁹ God made with Abraham an "everlasting covenant" that he will be the "father of a multitude of nations." Nations and kings will come from Abraham's lineage and the Lord will be their God (Gen. 17:4-8). Accordingly, Jesus, the ruler of Israel whose kingdom will have no end (Lk. 1:33), will forever be the God of Israel and the entire multitude of other nations.

and the present, which is why she deliberately fills the end of her song with nouns – servant, mercy, promise, ancestors, and descendants – that would resonate with an Israelite audience. Each word points back to the covenants and Israel’s relationship with God (Green 105). Mary is urging the audience to consider the coming of Jesus within the framework of salvation history; indeed, she is even urging the audience to see His arrival as the fulfillment of salvation history. Mary’s song ends on an almost doxological note, referencing the perpetuity of God’s salvific work.

Mary’s song closely echoes many Old Testament traditions, but none are more pronounced than its similarities to Hannah’s song. The parallels between the characters of I & II Samuel with the characters of Luke’s infancy narrative have already been presented, but an analysis of these two canticles makes this link more explicit.²⁰ The beginnings of both canticles clearly begin the same way: both women, celebrating His miraculous work of procuring their motherhood, proclaim their praises to the Lord from their innermost being. As noted previously, such personal exclamations signaled a particular kind of Israelite prayer wherein the speaker would praise the saving intervention of God. This exclamation would stereotypically follow with a list of particular reasons for the speaker’s praise. For example, Mary and Hannah both list as reasons for their praise God’s favor for the humble, poor, and hungry, His justice for the proud, rich, and full, and His covenantal protection to His faithful people. The resemblance between the two songs is remarkable, particularly for the repeated sentiment of God’s saving action for the lowly and oppressed.

Although they don’t provide as consistent a parallel as Hannah’s song, attention is still due to the use of other assorted Old Testament references in Mary’s song. Every single line of Mary’s song mirrors, at least to some degree, another piece of Old Testament literature. Whether or not all of these parallels were deliberate allusions to the Old Testament is difficult to conclude, especially since they don’t form a thorough reflection of any single text. However, the borrowed style, structure, and language throughout the canticle at least proves Luke’s familiarity with Israelite scriptures and demonstrates his intention to make his gospel continuous with Israelite tradition (Green 101). “Luke has composed [Mary’s song] to suggest to the reader that the real significance of Jesus is that he embodied in himself the mission of the old Israel,” (Tinsley 31).

With the major events of Mary’s visit to Elizabeth ended, Luke is able to return to the regular story. Continuing his use of step-parallelism, Luke prepares to narrate the birth accounts, first of John and then of Jesus. Just like he did with Mary’s travel into the hills of Judea, Luke uses the movement of his characters to advance the plot. Mary remains with her relative for three months (1:56), the point at which Elizabeth’s pregnancy would come to term. Luke articulates Mary’s departure in order to draw the audience’s full attention to Elizabeth and Zechariah. However, just because Luke clears the stage for Elizabeth does not necessarily mean that Mary returned to her house before the occasion of the birth. After all, it would have been unusual for Mary to depart immediately before the rest of their relatives came to celebrate John’s birth (1:58). Luke carefully organizes his gospel in a particular way such that he can direct the focus of the audience from character to character without necessarily following a conventional

²⁰ Figure III provided on page 15 gives a side-by-side view of Mary’s song relative to both Hannah’s song as well as other various canticles, psalms, and exclamations throughout the Old Testament.

chronological sequence (Green 106).²¹ Therefore, it is entirely possible that Mary stayed as one of Elizabeth's "relatives" to witness John's birth prior to her return home.

During the annunciation of Jesus's birth, Gabriel told Mary that Jesus's conception will happen by means of the Holy Spirit moving upon and overshadowing her (1:35). This may be an allusion to the overshadowing and descent of the "glory of the Lord" upon the ark of the covenant (Exo. 40:36) (Nolland 62). This allusion is further supported by the events of Mary's visit to Elizabeth. After David's victory over the Philistines at Geba (II Sam. 5:25), David "set out" and brought the ark, which had been with his company at the battle, back to Jerusalem (II Sam. 6:2, 12). Along the hilly (II Sam. 6:3) journey to Jerusalem, David stopped at the house of Obed-edom, whose house was evidently (due to David's ability to quickly change his mind) a short distance away from their destination (II Sam. 6:10). Already, several connections may be made between David's journey and Mary when she "set out" and traveled into the hill country near Jerusalem. While David was with the ark, he and his company danced and sang before the Lord (II Sam. 6:5), which is not unlike John's joyful leaping in the womb of Elizabeth, announcing the presence of Jesus. Before he brought the ark into Jerusalem, David questioned his worthiness to receive the ark into his house, asking, "How can the ark of the Lord come into my care?" (II Sam. 6:9). Elizabeth displays the same level of reverent humility when Mary proposes to stay with her, asking, "And why has this happened to me, that the mother of my Lord comes to me?" Finally, David stays with the ark in the house of Obed-edom for three months (II Sam. 6:11), which was the same length that Luke indicates Mary stayed in the house of Zechariah (Nolland 63, 66-67). Together, these possible parallels link Mary to the ark of the covenant²² and, by extension, equate Jesus, contained within Mary's womb, to the presence of God within the ark. And, if they were truly intentional, these connections also provide extra confirmation for the infancy narrative's rootedness in the tradition of I & II Samuel.

The visitation scene, including Mary's response to Elizabeth, is a crucial sequence in Luke's infancy narrative for its introduction of many key themes of his gospel. Perhaps the most important role of the scene is its characterization of God. The attributes that are applied to God this early in the narrative will provide a framework for how the audience will understand God's character throughout the rest of Luke-Acts (Tannehill 29-30). The most distinct characteristic of God in this scene is His agency. God is portrayed by both Mary and Elizabeth as a God who physically works in and through the world. It is God who acts to conceive Jesus in Mary's womb and God who acts to fulfill His promises. It is God who acts with favor upon His servant, who does great things, who shows strength with His arm, who scatters the proud, who lowers and lifts people from thrones, and who distributes and withholds food. Luke stresses the fact that God is active within the world because he wants his audience to interpret the rest of Luke-Acts with consideration to God's action behind it all.

²¹ Another example of this unorthodox narrative sequencing is at Jesus's baptism where John's imprisonment (3:20) immediately precedes Jesus's baptism by John (3:21). Of course, John did not baptize Jesus while in prison, nor does it make sense to conclude that John was released from prison between these two events. Rather, Luke must have been again clearing the stage of John so that the audience's attention can stay on Jesus for the following event.

²² The notion that Mary is the "ark of the new covenant" is familiar in Roman Catholic mariology. Further connections outside of Luke include the similarity of contents ("in [the ark] there were a golden urn holding the manna, and Aaron's rod that budded, and the tablets of the covenant" [Heb. 9:4]; Jesus embodies the fulfillment of the jar of manna [John 6:55], Aaron's rod [Heb. 10:14], and the Torah [Mat. 5:17]) and John the visionary's testimony of God's temple in heaven (the text quickly transitions from John seeing the ark of the covenant [Rev. 11:19] to John seeing the woman whose son ruled the nations [Rev. 12:1, 5]).

In Mary's song, God's agency is especially manifest through His justice and mercy. God brings justice to people who exploit, oppress, and hoard their wealth and food. God also shows abundant mercy to those who meekly face oppression, poverty, and starvation. While these are certainly radical images of societal reversal, these images show a profound aspect of God's character. God is simultaneously a warrior and an advocate. He is a judge whose punishing sentences are balanced by His compassionate pardons (*NISB* 1854). These images together reach a descriptive climax in the chiasm of the second half of the song (Tannehill 29). The revolutionary aspect of God's agency will be a prominent feature of God's activity in Luke's narrative, especially as taught in Jesus's ministry.

The Holy Spirit has a notable role in performing divine action, also. It was the Holy Spirit whom Gabriel specifically said would come upon Mary to conceive the Son of God (1:35). The Holy Spirit is again present at the visitation, filling Elizabeth with the inspiration necessary to deliver her prophetic statement (1:41). The Holy Spirit is present and active throughout the remainder of Luke-Acts, working to lead, guide, and fill people with the grace necessary to participate in salvation. His presence is explicitly mentioned at significant moments in the life of Jesus and the Church (Craddock 29).

Jesus's exalted nature also plays an important part of this scene. As stated earlier, Greco-Roman infancy narratives were used to reveal the backstory or hidden motivations and abilities of a character, leaving the audience with a deeper understanding of the character. John, whom the angel prophesied will prepare for the Lord God (1:16-17), clearly prepares for Jesus. The step-parallelism throughout the beginning of the gospel, wherein the elements of John's infancy immediately precede the corresponding elements of Jesus's infancy, narratively presents John as preparing the audience to see the events of Jesus's life. In the visitation account, John's leaping also physically points to the presence of the Lord in Mary's womb. As an extension of the parallels between John's Lord and Jesus, Elizabeth, in her prophetic outburst, overtly identifies the preborn Jesus as her Lord. Luke will continue to use the word "Lord" to refer to both Jesus and God the Father interchangeably throughout Luke-Acts, particularly after Jesus's resurrection (Kuhn 212). Mary herself hints at the exalted nature of the child in her womb. The epithets that she uses for God – He is her "Lord" (1:46), "savior" (1:47), and is "holy" (1:49) – are all terms that are used to describe Jesus in the infancy narrative (Johnson 42-43).²³ Finally, the parallels between the visitation and David's return to Jerusalem with the ark of the covenant equate Jesus to the presence of God contained within the ark. Together, all of these are evidence of Luke's christological objective to portray Jesus's nature as highly exalted, even on the same level as the divine.

The visitation scene, however, introduces more than just the attributes of God. For example, Mary's journey from Galilee (1:26) to the hills of Judea (1:39) may foreshadow the coming travel sequence of Jesus from Galilee to Jerusalem (9:51). Luke uses Jesus's journey as a literary way of unifying the latter half of Jesus's ministry while still advancing the plot. Likewise, Mary's journey to the house of Zechariah certainly binds its surrounding episodes together by allowing the characters to interact with each other, and, with her eventual departure, advances the narrative into John's birth scene. Although Mary's journey is significantly shorter than her son's, both journeys are also fundamental in establishing the character of their missions. Jesus's journey defines the missionary character of discipleship (Kuhn 80), which retroactively confirms Mary's status as a servant of the Lord (Green 95).

²³ Jesus, like the God who Mary magnifies, has also been called the "Lord" of John and Elizabeth (1:17, 43), the "savior" (2:11), and, even before His conception, was deemed "holy" by Gabriel (1:34).

In addition to the theme of physical, societal reversal that is upheld by the justice and mercy motifs of Mary's song, Luke also uses the visitation scene to demonstrate another type of reversal. Elizabeth's designation of Mary and Jesus as superior to herself was a remarkable display of humility – a humility that disregards social custom and upends the Roman beliefs about status and honor. The notion that Elizabeth, the elder of the two women, would declare herself as unworthy in the presence of the lowly virgin and her child embodies Jesus's message that "all who exalt themselves will be humbled, and those who humble themselves will be exalted," (14:11).

The main theological purpose of the passage is to show that the conception of Jesus is the fulfillment of all past promises and covenants. Keeping Israelite tradition constantly in view, Luke points to Jesus as the Davidic heir who will reign over the house of Jacob, the messiah who will bring deliverance to His people through a new exodus, and the Lord of John and Elizabeth who will establish a new kingdom. Although He is the fulfillment of Israelite expectation, Luke draws the audience's attention to the eschatological significance of His arrival. Jesus's conception is important, not only because it fulfills the promise made to Abraham, but also because it extends God's mercy to Abraham's descendants forever. God's plan of salvation is now in action; the savior is presently working within the womb of the lowly virgin to deliver His servants from their oppressors and to give them newness of life. With this soteriological framework in mind, Luke's audience is now ready to move forward into the next episode of the gospel where Zechariah announces the break of salvation's dawn (1:78).

Figure I.

The two halves of Mary's song show parallel images of Mary and Israel. Both Mary and Israel are (1) objectively **lowly**, (2) submissive to God as **His servant**, and, to both, (3) God's **mercy** endures **forever**.

God's Favor for Mary Part I: (Lk. 1:46b-50)	God's Favor for Israel Part II: (Lk. 1:51-55)
he has looked with favor on the lowliness of his servant, (1:48a)	He has... lifted up the lowly ; (1:52b)
he has looked with favor on the lowliness of his servant , (1:48a)	He has helped his servant Israel, (1:54a)
His mercy is for those who fear him from generation to generation , (1:50)	in remembrance of his mercy , according to the promise he made to our ancestors, to Abraham and to his descendants forever , (1:54b-55)

Figure II.

Robert C. Tannehill's literal translation of Mary's song intentionally disregards English grammar in order to retain the word order of the Greek. The fact that each line begins with strong action verbs seems deliberate. Translation, visualization, and emphasis by Tannehill (Tannehill 27).

- 46 **Magnifies** / my soul / the Lord
47 And **has found gladness** / my spirit / in God / my Savior
48 For **he has regarded** / the humble state / of his slave girl
 For behold henceforth / will call me blessed / all generations
49 For **has done** for me / great things / the mighty one
 And holy / his name
50 And his mercy / to generations / and generations / for those who
 fear him.
- 51 **He has done** / a mighty deed / with his arm
 He has scattered / proud people / in thoughts / of their heart
52 **He has put down** / mighty rulers / from thrones
 And **has exalted** / humble people
53 Hungry people / **he has filled** / with good things
 And rich people / **he has sent out** / empty
54 **He has helped** / Israel his / servant
 To remember / mercy
55 As he spoke / to our fathers / to Abraham / and to his seed /
 forever.

Figure III.

A side-by-side comparison of Mary's Song with certain Old Testament parallels. Mary's Song (middle) is continuous for easy comparison left and right. Some parts of Hannah's Song (left) are intentionally left out. The Old Testament references (right) are taken out of context, but chosen by the editor for their similarity.

Hannah's Song (I Sam. 2:1-10)	Mary's Song (Lk. 1:46-55)	Various Old Testament References
Hannah prayed and said, "My heart exults in the Lord; (2:1a)	And Mary said, "My soul magnifies the Lord, (1:46)	I will greatly rejoice in the Lord, (Isa. 61:10a)
my strength is exalted in my God. My mouth derides my enemies, because I rejoice in my victory. (2:1b)	and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior, (1:47)	my whole being shall exult in my God; (Isa. 61:10b)
Talk no more so very proudly, let not arrogance come from your mouth; for the Lord is a God of knowledge, and by him actions are weighed. (2:3)	for he has looked with favor on the lowliness of his servant. (1:48a)	"O Lord of hosts, if only you will look on the misery of your servant, and remember me, and not forget your servant," (I Sam. 1:11a)
	Surely, from now on all generations will call me blessed; (1:48b)	"Happy am I! For the women will call me happy," (Gen. 30:13a)
There is no Holy One like the Lord, no one besides you; there is no Rock like our God. (2:2)	for the Mighty One has done great things for me, and holy is his name. (1:49)	He sent redemption to his people; he has commanded his covenant forever. Holy and awesome is his name. (Ps. 111:9)
	His mercy is for those who fear him from generation to generation. (1:50)	But the steadfast love of the Lord is from everlasting to everlasting on those who fear him, and his righteousness to children's children, (Ps. 103:17)
The bows of the mighty are broken, but the feeble gird on strength. (2:4)	He has shown strength with his arm; he has scattered the proud in the thoughts of their hearts. (1:51)	you scattered your enemies with your mighty arm. (Ps. 89:10b)

He raises up the poor from the dust; he lifts the needy from the ash heap, to make them sit with princes and inherit a seat of honor. (2:8a)	He has brought down the powerful from their thrones, and lifted up the lowly; (1:52)	He raises the poor from the dust, and lifts the needy from the ash heap, to make them sit with princes, (Ps. 113:7-8a)
Those who were full have hired themselves out for bread, but those who were hungry are fat with spoil... The Lord makes poor and makes rich; he brings low, he also exalts. (2:5a, 7)	he has filled the hungry with good things, and sent the rich away empty. (1:53)	For he satisfies the thirsty, and the hungry he fills with good things. (Ps. 107:9)
He will guard the feet of his faithful ones... (2:9a)	He has helped his servant Israel, in remembrance of his mercy (1:54)	He has remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel. (Ps. 98:3a)
The Lord will judge the ends of the earth; he will give strength to his king, and exalt the power of his anointed.” (2:10b)	according to the promise he made to our ancestors, to Abraham and to his descendants forever.” (1:55)	He is mindful of his covenant forever, of the word that he commanded, for a thousand generations, the covenant that he made with Abraham, (Ps. 105:8-9a)

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